Anatomy: Orientation & Terminology

Study notes — Human Anatomy & Physiology unit. General reference terms used throughout perioperative practice.

Anatomical position

- Standing erect, facing forward, arms at sides, palms facing forward
- All directional terms below are described relative to this position

Directional terms

- Superior / inferior — toward the head / toward the feet
- Anterior (ventral) / posterior (dorsal) — toward the front / back
- Medial / lateral — toward the midline / away from the midline
- Proximal / distal — closer to / farther from the trunk (limbs)
- Superficial / deep — closer to / farther from the body surface

Body planes

- Sagittal plane — divides body into left and right
- Frontal (coronal) plane — divides body into front and back
- Transverse plane — divides body into upper and lower

Body cavities

- Dorsal cavity — cranial cavity + spinal cavity
- Ventral cavity — thoracic cavity + abdominopelvic cavity

Levels of organization

- Chemical → Cellular → Tissue → Organ → Organ System → Organism

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